and had what some have called a ‘spirit of adventure’.[53] Commenting on the Bhojpuri’s adventurous spirit, one scholar-official, in 1906, pointed out:[54]

> As fond as an Irishman is of a stick, the long-boned stalwart Bhojpuri, with this staff in hand is a familiar object striding over fields far from his home. Thousands of them have emigrated to British colonies and have returned rich men.

Rich or not, there were nearly 2,00,000 people, almost all men, from this region in Calcutta in 1901 and tens of thousands more in Assam, Bengal and Burma.[55] The region’s outmigrant to population ratio was above 10 per cent, higher than what it is for Kerala today. Weaver migrations, especially of Momin Muslim communities, towards the textile towns of Malegaon, Bhiwandi, Dhule and even Bombay in the 19th century, contributed to the emergence of a new corridor being established towards Maharashtra by the end of the 20th century.[56] Today, Bhojpuri mass male migration extends in all directions within the Indian subcontinent, especially westwards and southwards, with a new line opening to the Gulf countries. Annual migration to the Gulf from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar now exceeds that from Kerala.

Unlike the Bhojpuri world, the Chhota Nagpur Plateau of Jharkhand is a hilly region with significant tribal or adivasi populations and is also rich in mineral resources. As a result, its migration history is quite different. The ‘hill coolies’, or Dhangars or Oraons, of this region were said to be good workmen on indigo plantations in the early 19th century. They were among the first recruits for the sugar plantations of Mauritius in 1834.[57] Overseas migration continued only for a couple of decades and was a tiny fraction of overall seasonal migration within the region. Between 1880 and 1920, two significant migratory routes opened. One was a gender-balanced stream towards the tea gardens of Assam that led to more permanent migrations, and the other was a male-dominated stream towards the Jharia coalfields in Dhanbad, over-represented by landless caste groups.[58] Ranchi and Hazaribagh divisions had extremely high outmigration rates of over 10 per cent in the late 19th century, but over the next century these rates declined